The Korean War broke out in 1950, the year after Mao's communists had seized power in China, and lasted until 1953. At that time, it was imperative for China's new rulers to consolidate their grip on power and get support for a regime that large segments of the population may not necessarily be in favour of. Now, hundreds of thousands marched in anti-American demonstrations, and it is estimated that in the space of six months, in the wake of the Korean War, 710,000 people, who had been branded counter-revolutionaries and suspected of links to the old regime, were executed or driven to suicide.[28]

The situation after the disastrous Great Leap Forward was somewhat similar. A successful war would be a godsend for Mao and those who still supported him. Whether or not a direct connection between the war and his return to power can be positively verified by internal Chinese documentation, the fact is that he did manage to regain control of the Party and the state after the 1962 War. Several of his enemies were also purged while some remained. So, in 1966, Mao launched his Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution, during which all his political rivals were eliminated and he was elevated to a god-like status in China.

When taking into account China's regional ambitions and domestic politics at the time, it should be clear to every serious observer and analyst that the border dispute was only an excuse for launching the 1962 War. But, at the same time, it has to be remembered that China's attitude has consistently been that it is always right, and any attempt to challenge its claims, whatever they might be, is regarded as a 'provocation'. Treaties that China for one reason or another does not like are deemed 'unequal', and therefore not to be honoured.

As a journalist specializing in regional security issues in Asia, it is also not hard for me to detect parallels between the Sino-Indian border dispute and territorial disputes in the South China Sea. China may well be more open and less ideologically rigid today than it was in 1962, but its behaviour towards its neighbours remains the same.

China never controlled or ruled over any of the areas in India's northeast, which it today claims and includes in its maps, and the situation in the Spratly Islands in the South China Sea is strikingly similar. China, with a large U-shape on its maps, lays claim to virtually all of the Spratly Islands, which today are claimed in whole or in part also by Taiwan, the